

ARCANE THESIS OPENING V6

Written by

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EXT. 80'S NEW HAVEN STREET - DAY

STERLING MEMORIAL LIBRARY appears upside down in a puddle.

A boot splashes into it, breaking the tranquility. Well-dressed ERIC - 21 - walks purposefully down the street. A large leather BAG is slung over one shoulder. It is a sunny day, but storm clouds loom in the distance.

Eric is cool, slick, and seemingly at ease, but careful observer might notice his nails bitten to the quick or a thin splatter of mud on the cuffs of his coat and pants.

He steps into the library doors.

INT. STERLING READING ROOM - DAY

He pops out into a reading room where an OLD PROFESSOR (60) looms over a stack of papers, frowning deeply. He scrawls a frustrated edit into the margin. Eric notices him.

ERIC

I hope that's not mine, Professor.

The prof looks up, startled, then brightens upon seeing his best student.

OLD PROFESSOR

No, Eric, it's not. I don't believe
I've reached you yet.

He flips through the papers.

ERIC

Well, let me buy you a beer before
you do.

The professor laughs.

OLD PROFESSOR

Bribery?

He tut-tuts theatrically.

OLD PROFESSOR (CONT'D)

Hasn't anyone told you cheaters
never prosper?

ERIC

(with a game smile)

You assigned us Machiavelli this
week. You get what you pay for.

OLD PROFESSOR
Or, in this case, what I don't pay
for.

The prof chuckles again, putting the cap on his pen and
setting the paper briefly aside.

OLD PROFESSOR (CONT'D)
Where are you off to this fine
afternoon?

ERIC
Some friends and I are welcoming a
guest from out of town. You would
like him. He's a teacher.

OLD PROFESSOR
What does he teach?

ERIC
Applied Theology mostly.

OLD PROFESSOR
Theology? I didn't know you were
interested. Don't tell me you're
being lured away from political
science.

ERIC
No, no. I'm not particularly
religious. It felt like a good idea
to broaden my education.

OLD PROFESSOR
Ahh. Good. Be careful with the
study of god and the devil. They
are useful stories, but quickly
break down into superstitious
nonsense when held too close to the
light. The last thing we need is a
bright mind like yours trapped in
the art of bunk and hokum.

ERIC
(wryly)
It's really more of a science of
bunk and hokum.

The professor harumphs.

OLD PROFESSOR
In that case, Barnum & Bailey's is
offering a course you might find
enlightening.

Eric laughs, then looks at his watch. He realizes he is late. He abruptly steps away from the table.

ERIC
Good to see you, professor. I'll
try not to run off with the circus
until you've graded my essay.

OLD PROFESSOR
Goodbye, Eric. Always a pleasure.

Eric quickly walks out of the room

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Outside, Eric purposefully stride down the corridor.

He passes by a FRIEND.

FRIEND 1
Hey, Eric.

ERIC
(putting the facade back
on)
Hey! How are you doing?

He keeps walking. Another friend calls out to him.

FRIEND 2
Hi, Eric.

ERIC
John, hi. Looking good.

He keeps walking.

He passes a group of friends sitting and chatting.

FRIEND 3
There he is. Hey, Eric, hey!

He puts his head down and huffs out a frustrated breath,
pretending not to hear them.

He quickly rounds a corner to escape and almost runs
headfirst into someone coming the other way. His eyes flash
with rage as books clatter to the ground.

Cute sophomore NATALIE (19) adjusts her jostled glasses.

NATALIE

Hey! Watch where you're -- Oh hi,
Eric.

Eric composes himself in a blink and reaches down to start picking up books. Behind his grin, he is furious at the interruption.

ERIC

Hi, Nat. I'm so sorry. I like the
glasses.

NATALIE

You do? They're new.

He hands her the last book.

ERIC

Really? That's great. Anyways, I
gotta --

NATALIE

I looked for you at the party on
Saturday.

This interests him in a distant, carnal way.

ERIC

You did?

She nods.

NATALIE

I didn't see you.

ERIC

(slick)

You know you can see me whenever
you want.

He brushes an errant strand of hair back behind her ear. She grins shyly, a mischievous glint coming in to her eyes.

NATALIE

What about now?

Eric's grin is now one step from contemptuous, all interest shriveled up. Can she not read the room?

ERIC

(playing it off as a joke)

Let's not get carried away.

He slips behind her.

ERIC (CONT'D)
Tell you what. Why don't you just
sit pretty and we'll talk next time
I run into you.

He starts walking away.

NATALIE
Wait, don't you want my phone
number.

ERIC
I'll find you.

DARK STAIRS - DAY

Eric walks from the light of the corridor into a dingy
staircase.

He descends the stairs and rounds a corner, eventually coming
to a --

EXT. HIDDEN DOORWAY - DAY

The door is old and rusty, chained shut.

From the bag around his shoulders, he withdraws a LAUGHING
MASK and a RINGMASTER'S TOPHAT. We catch a glimpse of THE
BOOK that whispers indistinctly from the bottom of the bag.

Placing them over his face, he looks over his shoulder one
last time, the jovial boy replaced with a sinister grin.

He reaches into his pocket and withdraws a KEY, unlocking the
padlock.

INT. HIDDEN PASSAGE - DAY

Inside the door is a pitch black passage.

Briefly silhouetted by daylight, the door shuts behind him,
plunging the passage into darkness. The Ringmaster extends
his hand and snaps his fingers. A GLOWING BALL OF SCARLET
LIGHT appears in the air, hovering over his hand.

With this illumination, he walks down the hallway. The light
illuminates the dingy passage dirtying his boots.

Eventually, he reaches a second door and pushes it open.
Wind rushes past him as he steps through the threshold,
rustling his coat.

INT. SECRET LIBRARY - DAY

A group of three figures sit surrounding a podium. Light from a single cracked window slices in a narrow beam to illuminate the lectern.

Each of them are disguised as prominent literary characters.

THE BIG BAD WOLF paces back and forth behind the table, glaring down at THE SLY FOX who sits disinterestedly doing a crossword puzzle.

DEATH, her face obscured by a skeleton's grin and an X of tape over the mouth, sits apart from them, deftly manipulating a deck of TAROT CARDS.

RINGMASTER
Good afternoon, everyone.

The Big Bad Wolf looks over and nods dutifully at the Ringmaster.

THE WOLF
Sir.

The Fox glances up and gives a casual wave.

THE SLY FOX
Ringmaster.

Death draws a card and sets it on the table. Not like any traditional tarot deck, WELCOME appears with the illustration of a man reuniting with his family.

RINGMASTER
Thank you all for being prompt. It would not do to keep our guest waiting.

The Wolf settles into his chair as the Ringmaster walks to the back of the room and places THE BOOK, a heavy leather bound tome, on the lectern. Sinister whispers emanate from it.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
If there are no objections, The Society of the Crossroad shall come to order.

He slams his hand down on the book. Candles arrayed around the room spring to life, bathing the room in bloody radiance.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Let it be known, Mr. Scrivener,
that all are present.

Death jots down a note into a heavy journal.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
The agenda for today is as follows:
sunder the gates of limbo and free
the man who enabled our ascension
from ignorance,

He pauses to gauge the reaction.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Then to rescue a fallen world from
itself.

ALL ASSEMBLED
Seconded.

RINGMASTER
Should our gambit fail, your
prayers for mercy will fall on
eternally deaf ears. Bearing this
in mind, is there any business that
needs to be discussed before we
proceed.

Ringmaster looks around meaningfully. Death shakes her head.
So does Wolf, who then glances pointedly at Fox. Fox shakes
his head while distractedly erasing a word from his
crossword. Wolf takes this personally.

THE WOLF
I move the Fox be reprimanded.

The Fox doesn't look up.

THE FOX
I move the Wolf propose a four
letter word for 'Goose Egg'.

THE WOLF
Is this a joke?

THE FOX
It better not be, I'm kicking in
heaven's front door to break the
third, fifth, and sixth seals.
You're only opening one.

THE WOLF

Do you have something to say about me?

THE FOX

I've got it!

He smacks his crossword and looks coolly at the Wolf.

THE FOX.

A Zero.

The Wolf snarls and whips a hand toward the Fox. A gust of wind blasts the crossword to the floor. The Fox slowly looks from his now empty hands to the Wolf. The irises of his eyes ring with enchanted fire.

Ringmaster watches this. He looks over Death who overturns a card: The Tower - 'A house divided against itself...', and slips out of her chair.

The Fox raises his hand, flames beginning to wreath his fingertips when his arm is firmly grabbed by Death. The flames immediately snuff out.

He rips his hands away, the flame rekindling when suddenly, time freezes. The three are trapped stock still, their eyes jerking about helplessly.

The Ringmaster holds his pocket watch loosely in his palm.

RINGMASTER

"There is a time for everything,
and a season for every activity
under the heavens."

He walks over to this frozen followers.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

But not this. Not now.

He walks to the Fox.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

Would you tear out the eyes because
they cannot speak as the mouth?

He turns to the wolf.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

Would you dash out the tongue
because its sight stops at the
teeth?

He looks at Death.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
No. We must be whole today.

The faint sound of screaming begins in the distance.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Listen.

It grows louder.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Can you hear them?

The sound of fire accompanies the clamor.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
A million souls burning in a lake
of fire.

It fades slightly.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Who put them there? The Devil?
The serpent who revealed the fruit?
No. The gardener who planted the
fruit for them to find.

Now they are as helpless in death
as they were in life. Burnt by a
nature they did not choose. Are
you starting to understand what
that is like? To be helpless?

We see their eyes flick around.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Do you understand why it cannot
stay this way?

He puts a hand on Fox's shoulder. Fox gasps, returning to
the normal flow of time. He grabs onto Ringmaster's hand.

THE FOX
(shaky; out of breath)
I understand. I understand. I'm
sorry. I'm just... I'm scared.

RINGMASTER
Don't be afraid, Fox. We speak
with God's voice. Who can stand
against us?

Time restores to usual. Everyone collapses into a nearby chair except for Ringmaster who stays on his feet, charismatic as always.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Excellent! Are there any further objections?

Wolf kneels down and scoops something up. Then he stands up and offers Fox's crossword back to him, scraped off the floor. Fox takes it from him, skims through it, then tosses it aside. He takes his hand instead and Wolf pulls him to his feet.

They stand as one.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
Seeing none, we shall proceed.

He leads the group to the back of the library.

INT. LIBRARY DOOR - DAY

At the back of the library is an emergency exit. Ringmaster withdraws a pack of CHALK from his bag. The men each grab a stick.

In a montage, they draw on the door, each inking in graceful arcs and jagged runes. When they are done, an intricate SUMMONING CIRCLE stands before them. Death and Wolf continue the lines onto the ground, drawing protective circles around the four men.

They each step into their circle.

RINGMASTER
Let it begin.

He closes his eye, rallying his power. When he opens them, the room falls into monochrome. He looks down to his book.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
I watched as the lamb opened the first of the seven seals.

A deep sub-bass hum fills the room. He approaches to the sound of a single cello.

ALL ASSEMBLED
Come!

Thunder rumbles.

RINGMASTER

There before me was a white horse.
It's rider was given a crown and he
rode out as CONQUEST.

He steps forward to the door, raising his hand, he beats it once against the door. The sound echoes deeply through the air.

He pauses, fist against the door, when the room shifts to a freezing blue-gray. The ghostly afterimage of a white crown flashes onto his head. He drops to one knee under its weight. It is trying to conquer him.

Breathing deeply, he strains against the crushing weight and drags himself to his feet. There is the sound of a great lock opening. He strides back to his circle.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

When the lamb opened the second
seal.

ALL ASSEMBLED

Come and see!

The Wolf steps up next.

RINGMASTER

There went out another horse that
was red,

He approaches the door and knocks on it once. A drumbeat begins.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

And power was given to him to take
peace from the earth.

The room bleeds to a crimson light. Ancient war drums beat a merciless tune. A single horn calls out.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

And there was given to him a great
SWORD.

He covers his eyes in pain. He sees images of infinite war -- knowledge of incredible suffering overlaid in double exposure culminating in a nuclear fireball, over which flashes a ghostly sword.

He gasps, wrenching his eyes open and unleashes a primal yell in the face of the ultimate human cruelty. The image fades to the sound of a seal unlocking. He returns to his circle, laughing.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
And when he has opened the third
seal.

ALL ASSEMBLED
Come and see.

RINGMASTER
A black horse. And he that sat on
him had a pair of balances in his
hands.

The Fox steps up to the door and pounds his hand against it.
The light shifts to sickly yellow.

EXT. VISION DESERT - DAY

He stands in a vast desert. A pair of scales flash over its
expanse. He starts walking.

Day and night flash by in a vicious cycle. 40 days of
walking.

INT. SECRET LIBRARY - DAY

Unsteadily, Fox rises to his feet. He walks back to his
circle with the stumbling, dragging gait of a man lost in
that same desert. When he returns, the seal unlocks.

RINGMASTER
When he opened the fourth seal.

ALL ASSEMBLED
Come and see.

RINGMASTER
I saw a white horse.

Death walks up to the door. She pauses longer than the rest,

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)
And his name that sat on him, was
Death.

Then strikes it. Ringmaster watches her closely. She stands
infinitely still. Then starts to shiver uncontrollably. His
head twitches unnaturally. The sound of screams, of
whispered last wishes, of lamenting, creeps from inside his
mind along with a sinister whisper:

THE OTHER SIDE
Let go. Let go.

THE WOLF
What's happening?

Death thrashes again, her eyes have gone pure white. Two cards slip from his hands and fall to the ground. DEATH lands first which is then covered up by HELL. She drops to her knees, his body beginning to contort.

RINGMASTER
She cannot control it. Help her!

The Wolf runs forward to her and grabs her shoulder. Immediately, he tries to pull away, but his hand is stuck. He has no choice to grab on with the other hand. He grunts in pain, shaking his head.

THE WOLF
No! No. No. No.

He leans back in pain, then grits his teeth.

THE WOLF (CONT'D)
You can't have me. You can't have me! Come on, Death. Wake up. You have to wake up!

Death thrashes again. The voice louder in her mind.

THE WOLF (CONT'D)
(as if from far away)
WAKE UP!

Her eyes snap open, their normal color. She takes in Wolf on his shoulder, straining mightily to help her. She grips his hand and disconnects him, pushing him back to his circle, then standing confidently.

She turns to face the door and puts a finger to her lips.

DEATH
(whispered)
Shhhh.

A ghostly skull flashes over her mask. The voices fall silent in a gust of wind. The fourth seal unlocks.

THE WOLF
Yes!

The Fox looks over to the Ringmaster.

RINGMASTER

Two more seals, then I will finish
it. You must bear them, Fox, or we
are lost.

Fox nods. He walks over to the door.

Ringmaster calls out -

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

When he had opened the fifth seal,
I saw under the altar the souls of
them--

But his voice seems far away. Fox looks at the door with a
deep sorrow.

He pounds on it once. Sweat falls from his neck. He sinks
down the door. His formerly colorful clothes have been
bleached white. There is a click of a seal unlocking.

He raises his hand to strikes again and struggles mightily.
His face darts around in magical spasms.

THE FOX

Help.. me..

Death steps forward, so does Wolf. Despite their power, all
three begin to succumb to the arcane side effects.

RINGMASTER

No. NO.

He struggles. To move would be to risk destabilizing the
process, but to fail here would mean death.

He walks over to the group, but walking is like moving
through deep mud. As he does, the color channels around each
figure shift and distort. Fox listens to his echoing
footsteps as he approaches.

As Ringmaster reaches out his hand, Fox twists and pulls him
into the door, switching spots. He crashes into the
doorframe. The seal activates, pinning him in place. An
earthquake shakes the room.

The Fox shakes off the magical connection. When he looks up,
The Ringmaster, The Wolf, and Death are all stuck to the
magic door.

RINGMASTER (CONT'D)

What have you done?!

THE WOLF

Fox! Why?

They all groan under the mental strain.

The Fox reaches up slowly, swaying slightly on his feet, and takes off his mask. He is a young man of 20 with red hair and a thin face. He is crying.

THE FOX

I'm so sorry. But -- I know why He
planted that tree in the garden
now. It was too late to tell you. I
can't let this happen.

Ringmaster is thrashing wildly to escape the pull of the door, an animal caught in a trap.

RINGMASTER

I'll kill you! No!

The Fox's eyes ring with magical fire, drying up the tears.

THE FOX

This meeting is adjourned.

He closes his eyes to cast a spell.

RINGMASTER

(laced with magic)

STOP!

Ringmaster blasts out a wave of time controlling energy. The Fox opens his eyes, sets his stance, and raises his hands.

Flames engulf the room.

EXT. NEW HAVEN STREET - DAY

A firetruck races toward smoke rising in the distance.
Harkness Bells toll the time.

TITLE SEQUENCE